that could be placed in Castro's food or drink. The CIA's Technical Services Division was happy to oblige. Six pills containing botulinum toxin were handed to the Mafia in mid-March 1961.

Bissell and Edwards were given approval to use the Mafia by Allen Dulles and his Deputy Director, General Charles Cabell, in September 1960.[62] Did President Eisenhower authorise the operation? No smoking gun has emerged, though there is a lot of well-used ordnance lying around. A smoking gun was discovered to connect Eisenhower with the CIA plot to assassinate Patrice Lumumba, the Prime Minister of Congo (though others got to capture and murder him first).[63] Dulles believed that Eisenhower knew and approved of the plan to murder Castro. Plausible deniability was integral to CIA's *modus vivendi* and there is little in Dulles' career as DCI to suggest a rogue elephant at play.

Richard Bissell was fully aware of the progress of both the assassination planning against Castro and the collaboration with organised crime. As he told the Church Committee: 'Assassination was intended to reinforce the plan. There was the thought that Castro would be dead before the landing [making the invasion] either unnecessary or much easier.'[64] Seymour Hersch has argued that the assassination track was an integral part of the plan.[65] Howard Jones also believes that 'Bissell viewed assassination as the proper predecessor to the landing and reported directly to Dulles, who likewise considered assassination an appropriate part of the project.'[66] Jim Rasenberger, however, queries the suggestion that Bissell staked an operation of such magnitude on such a remote chance of success.[67] The CIA's internal history, completed in 1984, also argues that the CIA officials working on the plan knew nothing about the assassination planning.[68] In his posthumously published memoir, Bissell stated, 'as I moved forward with the plans for the brigade, I hoped the Mafia would achieve success.'[69]

What did JFK know? What did his brother know? Does plausible deniability or CIA malfeasance provide the better explanation. The essence of plausible deniability is that smoking guns are not left in places where they can be found. Yet few historians or investigators have concluded that the President or his brother were unaware of the attempts by the CIA to kill